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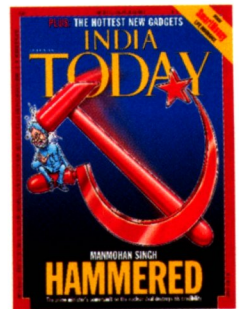
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I am having a rough time. Last week, we put power broker Amar Singh on our cover after dropping him from the INDIA TODAY power list earlier in the year. This week Prime Minister Manmohan Singh is on the cover after he won the trust vote on the nuclear deal. In October 2007 when it seemed like he had abandoned the deal, I wrote, "He has obviously lost his nerve, his spine, his conviction, and now his place in history." Well, after nine months, he has found all that I said he had lost, gambling his government's future on the deal and winning, even if controversially.

The episode marked the transformation of a puppet-prime minister to a leader in his own right. After four years, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh suddenly looked like he belonged to his office. By engineering a UPA victory in the Lok Sabha trust vote, he signalled his arrival as that entity nobody ever believed he could become: a politician.

His victory has come, quite literally, at a price. The shocking scenes of bundles of money being waved on the floor of the House with MPs accusing the Government of trying to bribe them for votes was a new low. The horse-trading in the run-up to the trust vote reminded me of what INDIA TODAY had written about the machinations leading to the ouster of the Morarji Desai government. In August 15, 1979 issue, we said, "The ugly politicians of today are faceless freaks: born of a reckless greed to grab power, fed on unscrupulous ambition to retain it, their ultimate lust is geared to self-preservation.... In their chronic quest for power, they have reduced the ethics of the power game to a squalid strip tease." Almost three decades later, nothing has changed.



Our Oct 2007 cover

Manmohan Singh's new-found stature and teflon reputation now will be put to the test. This victory will be a hard act to follow: for the first time, the Congress will expect him to lead like a politician. Freed of the Left and its compulsive objections, he will have to tackle inflation, deliver on promises around disinvestment, check subsidies and push through economic reform. Not to mention the pounds of flesh we will be forced to part with to his new fairweather friends for helping him win the vote. As writer R.L. Stevenson once said, "Everybody, sooner or later, sits down to a banquet of consequences." It is unlikely it will be too palatable.

We put our entire crack political team led by Editor Prabhu Chawla behind this week's cover story on the making of Manmohan Singh. The two-year-long battle of wits between the UPA and the Left has been a fascinating—and revealing chapter—in Indian politics. For the moment, Manmohan Singh should savour his victory as he has won a very important battle. Hopefully, he will seal his beloved nuclear pact in the coming months.

Not bad for a retired bureaucrat to go down in India's history books as the father of two great legacies—liberalisation and the nuclear deal.

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)